

Linguistic Framing of Police Violence: A Computational Comparison of Fox News and The New York Times

1. Introduction

The media do not merely report on events; they shape them. Through a systematic choice of grammar, vocabulary, and sentence structure, journalists and editors frame pivotal events in ways that influence the distribution of power, moral responsibility, and the weight of judgment among various stakeholders. These decisions determine how readers perceive "who the aggressor is", "who the victim is", and what credibility to give to accusations, especially in news reports about fatal police violence. This study examines how two major American news outlets, Fox News and The New York Times, used language in framing the killing of George Floyd, a Black man, on May 2020, by a police officer in Minneapolis.

The central research question is: *How do Fox News and The New York Times differ in their stylistic framing of the death of George Floyd, with respect to agency attribution, grammatical voice, epistemic hedging, and lexical choice?*

2. Engagement with Humanities

Linguistic framing as a field of research has its origins in Halliday's Systemic Functional Grammar (1985), which treats the clause structure as the "grammar of experience," the system whereby language encodes events and participants. In Halliday's framework all clauses identify participant roles (Actor, Goal, Beneficiary), select a process type (material, mental, verbal, relational), and specify circumstances. These grammatical choices, however, have implications in being influenced by bias as various lexicogrammatical realizations of the same underlying event construct different versions of that event, thereby emphasizing some participants over the others.

Halliday's framework was extended by Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA), which examines how grammatical choices encode ideology in public discourse (Fairclough, 1995; van Dijk, 1988). Sociologists have applied CDA to analyse the framing of race and police violence in American news media. Entman's (1990) work on television news representations of Black Americans documented systematic differences in how Black and white subjects were lexically and visually framed in crime reporting. More recently, Hirschfield and Simon (2010) illustrated how lexical and grammatical framings of violent encounters amongst police and civilians correlates systematically with racial identities of victims and editorial stances of news sources. Dependency-parsing and rule-based classification enable systematic comparison across a corpus. The four operationalizations delineated in this project, namely, transitivity, voice, hedging, and lexical framing reflect this.

3. Methodology

The project was originally planned to be a comparative study of three cases, including the killings of Tamir Rice (2014) and Philando Castile (2016). An in-depth analysis revealed a significant editorial trend: Fox News published no original article on the Rice case during the relevant period and only one original article on the Castile case, which was a reprint of an Associated Press story. Therefore, reports published by AP and then wired by Fox News were excluded. The final corpus comprises eight articles: three original Fox News articles and five original New York Times articles. The articles were collected via Google search (filtered by

date) and the Wayback Machine. The inclusion criteria required that the article: (a) be an factual news report, not opinions, (c) must focus on the killing of George Floyd, (d) be published within a 2 week window after the shooting, and (e) be authored by the original media source, not by syndicated journalism.

The articles were analysed using the dependency parser `en_core_web_sm` from SpaCy. For each sentence containing a target verb, four stylistic procedures from critical discourse analysis (CDA) were applied:

Transitivity (Halliday, 1985) concerns how the sentence structure assigns roles to the actors, grammatically termed actor, target, or beneficiary. The pipeline extracted the grammatical subject (`nsubj` or `nsubjpass`) and the direct object or agent per phrase (`dobj` or `agent` → `pobj`) of each target verb and then categorized them into five actor categories (Police, Victim, Civilian, Suspect, and Other) using a rule-based lexicon of key terms. Distributing these categories among the agents and patients of the verbs of violence implements Halliday's transitivity at the corpus level.

Grammatical voice (Fairclough, 1995) concerns the choice between the active and passive realization of the same underlying sentence. In the English passive voice, the patient or any other beneficiary of action is the *topic* (subject, patientive) which is then contrasted with the *comment* (predicate, agentive), usually incorporated as an indirect noun phrase (usually by-phrases). Passive constructions allow the semantic agent to be reduced to mere circumlocution ("Floyd was killed by the police officer") or to be suppressed entirely ("Floyd was killed"). The voice is determined a passive auxiliary verb (`auxpass`) or a passive subject (`nsubjpass`), which depends on the target verb. The proportion of sentences with a police agent that are realized in the passive voice grammatical obfuscation of the agent, as described in the literature on CDA.

Epistemic hedging (Hyland, 2005; van Dijk, 1988) concerns the linguistic markers of the speaker's certainty. In English, hedging often takes the form of modal auxiliary verbs like "could," "might," and "may" as well as adverbs like "allegedly," "apparently," and "perhaps." Hedging is operationalized as the co-occurrence of a target verb with any marker from a predefined lexicon at the sentence level. Selective hedging by actor category indicates what a medium considers fixed or provisional. Each target-verb sentence was compared with a set of hedging markers, `condition = (sent_words & HEDGES)`, returning Boolean `hedged` flag per extraction-row. Since journalists often rely on uncertain or unconfirmed evidence in days immediately after an event, hedging signals caution while presenting claims. Nevertheless, it has been strategically used to diffuse responsibility and subvert blame.

Lexical framing (Bolinger, 1980; Hirschfield & Simon, 2010) concerns the choice between quasi-synonymous phrasing with different evaluative burdens, for instance, "officer-involved shooting" versus "police shot," or "subdued" in place of "restrained." This framing was measured both by comparing verb frequency across different media and by using a curated lexicon of pairs of euphemistic and direct phrases, recording the frequency of occurrences of these pairs across the entire corpus of each medium. Each outlet's full corpus text was lowercased and searched for each phrase in the `EUPHEMISM_PAIRS` dictionary using Python's `str.count()` method, with results saved to `euphemisms.csv`. The statistical significance of the actor-category comparison was assessed using a χ^2 test of independence.

4. Results

The pipeline extracted 191 verb-instances from the 8-article corpus (160 from The New York Times, 31 from Fox News). The four framing devices are presented as follows:

Finding 1: Perhaps the most striking contrast between the two news sources is the use of hedging language (may, might, allegedly, reportedly, claimed). Fox News used hedging in around half the clauses where the civilians were the actors, whereas none (0%) were found in the NYT corpus. Clauses with police as the agents, Fox used hedging roughly 27% of the time, NYT did so to a slightly lesser degree of 9%, indicating that Fox held police-related actions at nearly three times the rate.

Finding 2: The most noticeable stylistic bias between the two news sources was an asymmetry in the grammatical voice used when the police were the semantic agent of a violent verb. Fox used passive constructions in 33% of such clauses, compared to 16% in NYT, a twofold difference between the two. This finding is consistent with the majority of literature regarding the agency-obscuring grammar that has been studied by (Fairclough, 1995). even when Fox News and The NYT identify police as the agents of an action, especially one involving violence, Fox is more likely to reframe them as the grammatical object, which is usually associated with recipients of their action. This might make it seem as if the police are the ones being acted upon, thereby subtly mitigating responsibility.

Finding 3: In clauses containing a violent verb, the two outlets distributed grammatical agency across actor categories in markedly different ways. Fox News named police as the agent in 33% of violent-verb instances, compared to NYT's 17%. NYT, however, named the victim as the patient of a violent-verb in 22% of instances, which Fox didn't do. Asymmetry was further revealed in the civilian category: Fox attributed violent agency to civilians in 13% of instances, while NYT did so in none. Both media sources were found to have high rates of unstated agents (Fox 40%, NYT 35%), reflecting the pervasiveness of nominalization in journalism.

Together these patterns suggest that the two outlets distribute violent agency across different participant categories: Fox spreading violence across police, civilians, and unstated actors; NYT keeping it concentrated on police and on the victim's experience of being acted upon.

Finding 4: Comparative frequency analysis of violent verbs between both media outlets revealed that NYT used direct violent vocabulary in higher absolute terms: "kill" appeared roughly three times more often (9 vs. 3 instances), "press" 5 times more (5 vs. 1), and "pin" 3 times more (3 vs. 1). This finding complicates an initial intuition that Fox might rely more heavily on direct violent terminology. Instead, NYT names violent acts directly more often, while Fox uses such verbs less frequently and, when it does, embeds them passive and hedged constructions.

An analysis of euphemisms reveals striking differences in word choice. In this dataset, The New York Times (NYT) used institutional euphemisms a total of 14 times, while Fox News did not use them once. Phrases such as "fatal encounter" (5 instances), "in police custody" (3 instances), and "subdued" (1 instance) appear only in the NYT, while Fox News used the simple phrase "police shot" only once. Furthermore, both outlets used the word "pinned" once each. This finding seems to contradict conventional logic: the NYT, which usually refers directly to violent events with verbs, also uses more institutional euphemisms. This suggests

that NYT operates on a two-tier system: direct identification of the perpetrator with verbs, but with institutional nominal framing. In contrast, Fox News, while using fewer euphemisms, also uses fewer verbs that directly describe violence.

A χ^2 test of independence on the agent category $\times$ outlet contingency table yielded $\chi^2(4) = 8.07$, $p = 0.089$. The difference wasn't significant at the conventional $p < 0.05$ threshold, reflecting the limited size of the Fox sub-corpus ($n = 31$ verb-instances). The directional patterns observed across all four framing devices are nonetheless consistent and theoretically interpretable, and should be treated as suggestive rather than definitive pending replication with a larger corpus.

5. Discussion

The findings together tell a coherent story. Fox uses less violent vocabulary, but it is couched in more passive and limited terms. The NYT directly names the violent acts in specific victims/patients. The two media outlets distribute influence, certainty, and evaluative weight differently among the same events. Interestingly, the analysis of euphemisms complicates this picture: the NYT uses a more institutional noun structure despite the direct word structure, suggesting two parallel registers within NYT's reporting. The finding that Fox relied solely on AP news for its coverage of Rice and Castile while producing original journalism for Floyd is itself a meta-level editorial decision. This editorial trajectory from zero original reporting on Floyd in 2014 to widespread coverage in 2020 suggests a dramatic change in Fox's engagement with the event.

There are several limitations to the interpretation of our results. First, the corpus is limited to a single case and author-signed articles, resulting in a total of eight articles and 191 verb-instances. The statistical significance is limited, especially for the Fox subcorpus ($n = 31$), and the trends observed should be considered indicative rather than definitive. The original three-case design was abandoned during corpus collection when it was discovered that Fox News' reporting of the Castile and Rice cases consisted almost exclusively of syndicated AP stories, a finding that in itself reveals notable editorial biases but precludes any direct linguistic comparisons across cases. A meaningful extension to this would be to compare media reports of the protests following Floyd's death.

6. Bibliography

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